

Ohio River South Shore Trail – Phase I (ORSST – PH1) Project Description

The Ohio River Trail (ORT) is a proposed 41-mile multi-use trail along the Ohio River and its tributaries, from Coraopolis, Pa (near Pittsburgh) to Ohioville, Pa. (near East Liverpool, OH). The ORT is part of the Rivers of Steel National Heritage Area, Lewis & Clark Eastern Legacy Trail, Pittsburgh to Cleveland Trail, and a portion of the Underground Railroad Bicycle Route, Pittsburgh spur, PA Bicycle Route A, and is a candidate for part of the U.S. Bicycle Route 50. The proposed ORT will also follow parts of the historical "Great Path" and the original "Lincoln Highway."

The Pennsylvania Department of Conservation and Natural Resources (PA-DCNR) has supported the Ohio River Trail Council (ORTC) vision by awarding grants for the Ohio River North Shore and Ohio River South Shore Feasibility Studies. For this project, the emphasis is to commence the implementation of the Ohio River South Shore Trail (ORSST) Feasibility Study.

The Ohio River South Shore Trail – Phase I (ORSST-PH1) Project is a collaboration between the Ohio River Trail Council, Montour Trail Council, Friends of the Riverfront, National Park Service, Federal Highway Administration, PennDOT, Borough of Coraopolis, Moon Township and Allegheny County.

The ORSST-PH1 is a key project within the overall Ohio River Trail Corridor that specifically improves the efficiency of the existing transportation system incorporating PA Bicycle Route A; enhances multi-modal choices including bike/ped and supports transit access; promotes private sector reinvestment and development patterns and creates a cohesive green corridor along existing PA Route 51.

The ORSST-PH1 project is an exciting transportation prospect that consists of off-road and on-road bicycle and pedestrian facilities linking the existing 46-mile Montour Trail to the Ohio River.

The ORSST-PH1 project begins on-road at the pending 78-acre Allegheny County Sport and Athletic Complex located at Montour Junction on a former Montour Railroad Engine Terminal and Railyard, to the Borough of Coraopolis' downtown commercial corridor (near a proposed transit center at the former P&LE Railroad Station). The trail continues along Broadway Street, First Ave, Kendall Street, Birch Ave, Watt Street, Third Avenue Right-of-Way, and American Bridge Way.

From this point, an off-road route that is a two-way separated trail is to be developed along State Route-51 between Coraopolis and the Sewickley Bridge. This route traverses along the north shoulder of PA Route-51 along a PennDOT Right-of-Way and a Duquesne Light Utility corridor to the planned Moon Township Ohio River Waterfront Park. Next, the trail utilizes Ambulance Way and the existing traffic signal to cross State Route-51 to the south shoulder to access the Sewickley Bridge. Once on the bridge, the route becomes a "Share the Road" condition to the Ohio River North Shore Extension Trail, which includes Sewickley, Edgeworth, Leetsdale, and Ambridge.

The project also encompasses the development of two trailheads. First, the planned shared trailhead facility between the Ohio River Land Trail and the Three Rivers Water Trail located at the proposed Moon Township Ohio River Waterfront Park. The existing Port Authority of Allegheny County's Thorn Run "Park and Ride Lot" serves as a second trailhead. All Port Authority buses have bike racks via the Rack 'n Roll Program. In addition, there is bus service to the Pittsburgh International Airport supporting the touring cyclist.

The project includes all improvements to achieve a safe and accessible route for both pedestrians and bicyclists. At this time, \$400,000 in total funding will employ a consultant to prepare engineering specifications and bid documents to begin the construction of the 3.5-mile ORSST-PH1. The Project will use approved federal dollars from a \$200,000 Transportation, Community and System Preservation Program (TCSP) Grant from the Federal Highway Administration as a match to PA-DCNR \$200,000 Community Conservation Partnerships Program Grant.

Enhancements to the on-road route, which contains PA Bicycle Route-A along Fourth and Fifth Avenues through Coraopolis, includes on-road bicycle route pavement markings and signs to delineate the route for cyclists and to alert motorists of the "Share the Lane" condition. Fourth and Fifth Avenues are one-way travel roadways 40 and 31-feet wide respectively. Fourth Avenue is composed of dual westbound lanes with parallel parking on each side with a posted 35-mph travel speed. Fifth Avenue is a single eastbound lane with parallel parking on each side with a posted 25-mph travel speed.

The off-road trail development includes shoulder widening, drainage repairs and replacements, storm culvert widening, right-of-way clearance, environmental and highway occupancy permitting. The project also includes concrete curb and sidewalk repairs, pedestrian crossing improvements such as curb ramps, crossing pavement markings, crossing signal upgrades, and ADA compliance at curb ramps and sidewalks. In addition, the project includes wayfinding signs for walkers and cyclists to market an area's resources while evoking a sense of character and improving accessibility and public safety.

This completes the first phase the Ohio River South Shore Trail, which provides a critical missing cohesive multi-modal spine, which also ensures connectivity with the Ohio River. The ORTC conceived the ORT as an opportunity for connectivity. In subsequent phases, the ORT will continue from the Sewickley Bridge through Allegheny and Beaver Counties' traversing twenty-four additional riverfront communities on both the north and south shores of the Ohio River and ultimately linking with the Great Ohio Lake-to-River Greenway (GOLTR) in Ohio as referenced in the Ohio River North & South Shore Feasibility Studies. The GOLTR is a trail that extends from Lake Erie to the Ohio River, which is approximately 90% completed.

Consequently, the ORT will serve as a significant segment in the interconnection of existing land trails in Maryland, Ohio, and Pennsylvania. Specifically, the proposed ORT will connect the states northwest of the Ohio River to the Great Allegheny Passage forming a mega-trail from the Great Lakes region to Washington D.C.